



Changes in US Environmental Policy Under the Trump Administration: An Economic Perspective¹

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Abstract

Since President Donald Trump took office for a second time in January 2025, his administration has initiated a flurry of actions to fundamentally alter environmental policy in the US. These actions include, among other things, climate change policy, renewable and fossil-fuel energy production, public land management, water and air pollution policy, and methods that must be used by federal agencies when performing economic analyses of environmental regulations. The Trump administration has promoted these changes by saying that they will improve the economy and increase government efficiency. In contrast to this rhetoric, these changes are likely to reduce rather than increase economic efficiency, as well as increase costs and reduce welfare for American citizens and people around the world. In this paper, we document and discuss the multiple ways in which the Trump administration's recent and proposed changes related to the environment violate foundational principles of environmental economics in ways that will likely lead to lower overall social welfare.

Keywords Environmental economics foundations · Economic efficiency

1 Introduction

Since President Donald Trump took office for a second time in January 2025, his administration has initiated a wide array of significant actions that fundamentally change US environmental policy and the underlying scientific infrastructure that supports policy decisions. These changes impact policies related to climate change, renewable and fossil fuel energy production, public land management, water and air pollution, and other areas. The Trump administration has sought to overturn long-standing environmental regulations and make

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changes in the rules on how environmental regulations are evaluated, implemented, and enforced, including how federal agencies conduct economic analyses of environmental regulations, methods that have been rigorously vetted for consistency with state-of-the-art economics. The actions of the Trump administration also reach well beyond the US federal government. It has significantly cut funding not only to federal agencies but also to universities and non-governmental organizations (NGOs) engaged in environmental research and has challenged the environmental policies of US states.

The Trump administration has promoted these changes by saying they will improve the economy and increase government efficiency. In rolling out a sweeping set of changes in environmental policy, US Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) Administrator Lee Zeldin stated: “Today is the greatest day of deregulation our nation has seen. We are driving a dagger straight into the heart of the climate change religion to drive down cost of living for American families, unleash American energy, bring auto jobs back to the U.S. and more” (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025a). In contrast, a *New York Times* article summarized the potential consequences of these changes by saying “President Trump has severely damaged the government’s ability to fight climate change, upending American environmental policy with moves that could have lasting implications for the country, and the planet” (New York Times 2025a).

In this paper, we discuss many of the changes affecting environmental policy initiated by the Trump administration in roughly its first 100 days and specifically focus on the multiple ways in which these changes fail to adhere to the prescriptions of well-accepted economic principles and scientific findings. By focusing almost solely on the direct cost savings of their proposed changes without comparable regard for their environmental harm, the Trump administration changes are likely to reduce rather than increase economic efficiency. In the next section, we describe some foundational principles of economics related to the concept of efficiency – a concept that the Trump administration says it prioritizes – and their implications for environmental policy. After summarizing these principles, we review specific changes put forward by the Trump administration and discuss ways in which they are inconsistent or antithetical to these foundational economic principles. We end by identifying several steps that economists can take to promote scientifically sound environmental policy during this period of rapid change.

Our critique of actions by the Trump administration is not motivated by partisan politics or political agendas. We wrote this article because of concerns about the failure of the Trump administration to abide by core principles of economics and the potential for substantial long-term harm with severe consequences for the health and welfare of Americans and people around the world. It should be a goal of all political parties and all administrations to achieve environmental objectives through policy adoption where benefits outweigh costs and objectives are achieved in a cost-effective manner. Of course, no administration is perfect in this regard. There are numerous examples where prior administrations have failed to enact efficient environmental policies or used cumbersome regulations rather than incentive-based mechanisms to achieve environmental objectives (e.g. Segerson et al. 2024). However, since the formation of the EPA in 1970 under the Nixon administration, most prior administrations of both political parties have supported trying to achieve environmental objectives where there is evidence for their beneficial effects. Moreover, since the Reagan administration executive order requiring benefit-cost analysis for all major rules including environmental regulations (EO 12291; US National Archives 1981), all prior administra-

tions have recognized that efficiency requires a balancing of benefits and costs. In contrast, Trump administration policies amount to a rejection of fundamental principles of economics, particularly those related to improving the efficiency of environmental policy.

2 Foundational Economic Principles

The discipline of economics, and by extension environmental economics, is motivated by the desire to understand how to allocate the world's limited resources to generate the greatest possible value to society. Maximizing aggregate social welfare requires using all resources efficiently. This means that i) any given level of output or service is being produced at the lowest possible cost (cost-effectiveness) and ii) any adopted change or reallocation of resources generates benefits that exceed the costs.¹ A policy can have goals other than economic efficiency, such as goals related to the distribution of benefits and/or costs across different groups. Nonetheless, making efficient use of available resources is a key policy goal.²

In addition to formalizing the concept of economic efficiency, economics has well-developed principles related to achieving efficiency. These principles, which are core concepts central to the discipline of economics, include the following:³

1. In the presence of market failures, including those from environmental externalities and public goods (such as research, information and infrastructure, as well as clean air, clean water, and public lands), unregulated markets will not generally generate an efficient outcome.⁴ Such market failures provide an economic efficiency rationale for government policies.
2. Determining whether a regulation or policy increases efficiency requires consideration and comparison of both benefits and costs. Such an analysis should strive to incorporate all social benefits and costs even though complete accounting is often not possible. Benefits and costs include those affecting people now or in the future arising from changes in both market and non-market goods and services, as well as intended and unintended consequences of the regulation or policy. Eliminating regulations or

¹ More specifically, overall economic efficiency requires that outputs and services are being allocated across individuals such that it is not possible to reallocate to make one person better off without making another person worse off (a Pareto optimal solution). A reallocation or change for which benefits exceed costs is then equivalent to a potential Pareto improvement (equivalently, a reallocation that passes a Hicks-Kaldor compensation principle) where, with appropriate transfers (even if not actually made), a true Pareto improvement under which no one is worse off can be made. Unless otherwise stated, as is common in economics, we use the term "social welfare" to refer to aggregate net benefit, recognizing that other concepts of social welfare that incorporate distributional or ethical considerations are also possible. Under this utilitarian definition of social welfare, an increase in efficiency is equivalent to an increase in social welfare.

² Of course, this entails eliminating wasteful use of resources. However, the Trump administration's focus on eliminating "waste, fraud, and abuse" in practice is often used as justification to eliminate government programs (and associated services or outputs) based on the administration's articulated priorities. Although eliminating these programs will reduce costs, it will not promote efficiency if those programs generate benefits that exceed their costs.

³ These core principles, among others, are covered in detail in standard textbooks in microeconomic theory and environmental economics. See, for example, Baumol and Oates (1988), Freeman et al. (2014), Hanley et al. (2007), Just et al. (2004), Mas-Colell et al. (1995), and Phaneuf and Requate (2017).

⁴ See Coase (1960) for exceptions.

policies for which aggregate social benefits exceed aggregate social costs will reduce efficiency and overall social welfare.

3. Benefit-cost analyses typically aggregate benefits and costs that accrue over time into a single present value of net benefits. Current best practices discount future benefits and costs using methods that reflect best available estimates of society's time preference for consumption and the opportunity cost of capital.
4. Uncertainty over benefits or costs of policies is common, especially when considering future benefits and costs in a changing world. Uncertainty does not imply that there are no benefits or costs, nor that the best estimate of those benefits or costs is zero.
5. Because a policy can have goals related to the distribution of benefits and costs across different groups, a well-designed policy analysis should include this information.
6. The level of government (e.g., local, state, regional, or national/federal) most appropriate for making efficient environmental policy decisions depends on the extent or scale of interjurisdictional spillovers, as well as differences in benefits and costs across jurisdictions.
7. Addressing global public goods or bads requires international collaboration to avoid the classic free rider problem that typically arises with the provision of public goods. An equilibrium where all countries follow short term strategies of apparent self-interest will not achieve an efficient outcome.

Principle 1 provides the economic efficiency rationale for government policy. Principles 2–5 relate to evaluating the efficiency and distributional implications of policies using benefit-cost analysis. Principles 6 and 7 relate to appropriate levels of governance (domestic and international). We chose this subset of economic principles to highlight here because they seem particularly relevant when considering recent actions by the Trump administration.

3 Recent Trump Administration Actions

The Trump administration has initiated a set of sweeping changes related to environmental policy in the US. Here we review some (but not all) of the important changes undertaken in the first few months of the Trump administration and discuss how these changes are inconsistent with the principles of economics discussed in the prior section and how these are likely to lead to reductions in social welfare.

3.1 Climate Change

Many of the environmental actions taken by the Trump administration relate to climate change and reflect President Trump's views on climate science. President Trump has said that "The concept of global warming was created by and for the Chinese in order to make U.S. manufacturing non-competitive" (X.com 2012), "If you have a windmill anywhere near your house, congratulations, your house just went down 75 percent in value. And they say the noise causes cancer..." (McDonald 2019), and more recently "the ocean is going to rise one eighth of an inch over the next 400 years" (New York Times 2024).⁵ Such statements are in striking contrast to the weight of scientific evidence about the severe threat

⁵ See McDonald (2024) for a recent fact checking of Trump's statements on climate change.

posed by climate change as found by the International Panel on Climate Change (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) 2023) and the US National Climate Assessment (US Global Change Research Program (USGCRP) 2023).

Two prominent examples of the Trump administration's climate change policy are the US withdrawal from the Paris Climate Agreement immediately following the Presidential Inauguration and efforts to eliminate almost all consideration of climate impacts in policy discussions and decisions.

3.1.1 Pulling the US Out of International Climate Agreements

On the very first day of the second Trump administration, President Trump signed Executive Order 14162 "Putting America First in International Environmental Agreements" to withdraw the US from the Paris Climate Agreement (EO 14162; White House 2025a). Further, this executive order withdrew the US "from any agreement, pact, accord, or similar commitment made under the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change". This was the second time that President Trump has pulled the US out of the Paris Climate Agreement, having also done so in 2017 during his first term. In signing the executive order, President Trump said "I'm immediately withdrawing from the unfair, one-sided Paris climate accord rip-off" (ABC News 2025).

Maintaining climate stability is a global public good that requires countries around the world to cooperate to reduce greenhouse gas emissions (Principle 7). International agreements, like the Paris Climate Agreement, can make it possible for all countries to be better off with an agreement than without one (Principle 7). However, such agreements are difficult to sustain because of the free rider problem with public goods provision (Barrett 1994 1999; Mason et al. 2017). Continuing the current path of emissions will push global concentrations of greenhouse gases well above the levels needed to limit warming to 2 degrees C or below and into ranges likely to lead to large-scale global climate-related losses (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) 2023). Since the US is the second-largest emitter of greenhouse gases and has the largest cumulative emissions of any country, it is challenging to envision a comprehensive global climate change agreement without the US changing its position.

One option to address the problem of countries free riding on others to reduce emissions is for a group of countries to form a "climate club" (Nordhaus 2015) in which participating countries levy a tariff on imports from countries without an effective carbon policy. Such a strategy is being pursued by the European Union with its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (European Commission 2023) and was recently adopted by the UK (UK Government 2023). It is not without irony during a trade war initiated by the Trump administration to note that tariffs can be used effectively as a mechanism to tackle the free rider problem for global public goods.

3.1.2 Eliminating Climate Change Considerations in Federal Policy

In line with pulling out of international climate agreements, the Trump administration has sought to eliminate any consideration of the well-established impacts of climate change on welfare through its impacts on the economy, health, natural disasters, etc. (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) 2023; US Global Change Research Program

(USGCRP 2023). This effort has taken several forms, including attempts to overturn the Endangerment Finding regarding the damages from greenhouse gas emissions and the elimination of the use of the social cost of carbon to incorporate those damages into policy discussions and decisions.

In 2009, the EPA found that six greenhouse gases “threaten the public health and welfare of current and future generations” and that emissions from motor vehicles contribute to greenhouse gas air pollution (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2009). This conclusion, known as the “Endangerment Finding”, notes that “the body of scientific evidence compellingly supports this finding,” drawing on, among other things, major assessments by the US Global Change Research Program (USGCRP), the International Panel on Climate Change (IPCC), and the National Research Council (NRC) (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2009). As part of his “Unleashing American Energy” executive order (EO 14154; White House 2025b), President Trump called for a reconsideration of the Endangerment Finding, which provides EPA with the legal authority to regulate greenhouse gas emissions under Section 202(a) of the Clean Air Act (US Code 2013). Related to this, in June 2025, the EPA proposed making a finding that greenhouse gas emissions from fossil-fuel-fired power plants do not contribute significantly to air pollution. Such a finding would eliminate the requirement to regulate these emissions under the Clean Air Act, thereby allowing the EPA to repeal all greenhouse gas emissions standards for these plants (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025b). In calling for a reversal of the Endangerment Finding, the administration argued that it was not supported by evidence and that “the combined six gases contribute some mysterious amount above zero to climate change and that climate change creates some mysterious amount of endangerment above zero to public health” (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025c). Here, the Trump administration seems to be saying that, because there is uncertainty, damages should be ignored, in clear violation of Principle 4.

Building on the Endangerment Finding, the social cost of carbon has been used to assign a monetary value to damages from carbon emissions, allowing for the inclusion of these damages in benefit-cost analyses and, consequently, in government decision-making. However, the executive order “Unleashing American Energy” (EO 14154; White House 2025b) disbanded the Interagency Working Group (IWG) on the Social Cost of Greenhouse Gases, withdrew any guidance or recommendations previously made by the IWG, including their technical support documents and estimates of the social costs of greenhouse gases (carbon dioxide, methane, and nitrous oxide), and called for possible elimination of the use of the social cost of carbon by the federal government. This executive order stated that “The calculation of the ‘social cost of carbon’ is marked by logical deficiencies, a poor basis in empirical science, politicization, and the absence of a foundation in legislation.” The same executive order also directed the EPA Administrator to “issue guidance to address these harmful and detrimental inadequacies, including consideration of eliminating the ‘social cost of carbon’ calculation from any Federal permitting or regulatory decision” (EO 14154; White House 2025b). On May 5, 2025 the Office of Management and Budget (OMB), in consultation with EPA, issued guidance that stated that “it is no longer Federal government policy to maintain a uniform estimate of the monetized impacts of greenhouse gas emissions” and that “the circumstances where agencies will need to engage in monetized greenhouse gas emission analysis will be few to none” and only where existing laws require such calculations (Office of Management and Budget (OMB) 2025). In those limited cir-

cumstances, agencies should “limit their analysis to the minimum consideration required to meet such a statutory requirement” and not monetize the impacts of emissions because the uncertainties in performing monetized impacts quantifications are too significant (Office of Management and Budget (OMB) 2025).

Eliminating consideration of climate-related impacts of policies or decisions, or, equivalently, eliminating the use of a social cost of carbon in regulatory analyses, essentially treats the climate-related costs associated with actions such as increased fossil fuel combustion as though they are non-existent. In other words, it erroneously claims those impacts are not occurring or simply assigns them zero value. As a recent headline in the New York Times said, “What’s the cost to society of pollution? Trump says zero” (NY Times New York Times 2025c). Ignoring the social cost of carbon is a clear violation of at least two fundamental principles of economics noted above: (1) that policy decisions that seek to promote efficiency should consider all social costs and benefits (Principle 2), and (2) that uncertainty about the damage associated with climate change does not imply that they are zero (Principle 4).⁶

The decision to treat the social cost of carbon as zero is particularly striking in the face of the carefully vetted and peer reviewed estimates of the social cost of carbon released by the US EPA in 2023 (US EPA US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2023a). The estimates for the social cost of carbon in 2020 range from \$120 to \$340/ton, depending on the discount rate chosen. These estimates are similar to findings in other recent studies on the social cost of carbon (Rennert et al. 2022; Tol 2023). The US EPA estimates were generated by the Inter-Agency Working Group and drew directly from recommendations of a 2017 expert review committee formed by the National Academy of Sciences (National Academy of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine 2017). The analyses were carefully vetted both through the Federal Register public comment process and by an expert panel of reviewers. One of those reviewers, Dr. Maureen Cropper, noted that the updated assessments represent “a huge advance in estimating the US Social Cost of Carbon” (Institute for Policy Integrity Institute for Policy Integrity 2025). Neither the 2017 NASEM report nor of the expert reviewers of the 2023 document in any way support the Trump administration’s position that existing uncertainties imply that the federal government should not include damages from greenhouse gas emissions in policy decisions (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2023b).

Consistent with overturning the Endangerment Finding and eliminating use of the social cost of carbon, the Trump administration also plans to disregard global climate change costs in its policy deliberation. In the executive order “Unleashing American Energy” (EO 14154; White House 2025b), sect. 2(g) states that “the global effects of a rule, regulation, or action shall, whenever evaluated, be reported separately from its domestic costs and benefits, in order to promote sound regulatory decision-making and prioritize the interests of the American people.” Of course, if all countries follow this policy, we will have an inefficient solution (Principle 7). By failing to consider costs imposed on other countries and being unwilling to engage in international negotiations, the US has reduced the likelihood of an international agreement and, given the outsized role of US GHG emissions in the world, effectively guarantees that emission reductions will not achieve the global optimum.

⁶ Burning of fossil-fuels are also associated with local air pollution so weakening climate change policy could also affect local air quality. Prior studies by US EPA show highly positive net benefits from the regulation of air pollution under the Clean Air Act (US EPA 1997 1999 2011).

3.2 US Energy Production

President Trump campaigned on increasing US fossil fuel production (“drill, baby, drill”) and followed through on that promise on his first day back in power with the issuance of “Unleashing American Energy” (EO 14154; White House 2025b) and a second executive order “Declaring a National Energy Emergency” (EO 14156; White House 2025c). Both executive orders emphasized the need to increase energy production and consumption, particularly of fossil fuels. “Unleashing American Energy” stated that, while the US has an abundance of energy resources, “burdensome and ideologically motivated regulations have impeded the development of these resources, limited the generation of reliable and affordable electricity, reduced job creation, and inflicted high energy costs upon our citizens. These high energy costs devastate American consumers by driving up the cost of transportation, heating, utilities, farming, and manufacturing, while weakening our national security” (EO 14154; White House 2025b). The declaration of a “National Energy Emergency” allows the Trump administration authority “to facilitate the identification, leasing, siting, production, transportation, refining, and generation of domestic energy resources” and to expedite environmental reviews of energy projects (EO 14156; White House 2025c). Both executive orders give priority to energy production over environmental objectives such as clean air, clean water, endangered species protection, or controlling climate change. Many other executive orders prioritizing energy and mineral development have followed.⁷

This set of executive orders emphasizes the economic and national security benefits from increased production and consumption of fossil-fuel energy but downplays or ignores the associated costs, such as the negative climate, air pollution, and public health consequences of increased use of fossil fuels. A National Research Council study found that the use of coal for electricity generation released 1 ton of CO₂ per megawatt and caused non-climate air pollution damages of 3.2 cents per kilowatt-hour of electricity (National Research Council 2010). The equivalent figures for natural gas were 0.5 tons of CO₂ and 0.16 cents per kilowatt hour. Renewable energy did not produce either carbon emissions or air pollution during electricity production. Assuming a carbon price of \$100 per ton of CO₂, the climate and air pollution costs would be 13.2 cents per kilowatt-hour for coal, 5.16 cents per kilowatt-hour for natural gas, and \$ 0 per kilowatt-hour for renewable energy. Of course, there are some external costs from production of solar panels and wind turbines, but even factoring these in would not change the basic conclusions that coal has high external costs and renewables have low external costs (National Research Council 2010).

The executive orders promoting fossil fuel production come at a time of record oil and natural gas production in the US (US Energy Information Administration (US EIA) 2025a, US Energy Information Administration (US EIA) 2025b). In 2024, the US produced 13.2 million barrels of oil per day (US Energy Information Administration (US EIA) 2025a), which exceeds the production levels of any other country, including Saudi Arabia, at any

⁷These include “Establishing the National Energy Dominance Council” (EO 14213; White House 2025d), “Addressing the Threat to National Security From Imports of Copper” (EO 14220; White House 2025e), “Immediate Measures to Increase American Mineral Production” (EO 14241; White House 2025f), “Protecting American Energy from State Overreach” (EO 14260; White House 2025g), “Reinvigorating America’s Beautiful Clean Coal Industry and Amending Executive Order 14241” (EO 14261; White House 2025h), “Ensuring National Security and Economic Resilience through Section 232 Actions on Processed Critical Minerals and Derivative Products” (EO 14272; White House 2025i), and “Unleashing America’s Offshore Critical Minerals and Resources” (EO 14285; White House 2025j).

time in history. Neither oil nor natural gas prices in 2025 are particularly high by historical standards, and certainly nowhere near record high prices, even ignoring inflation (US Energy Information Administration (US EIA) 2025c, US Energy Information Administration (US EIA) 2025d). Given this, it is hard to see that the US is in an “energy emergency.”

If there truly is an energy emergency, then the production of all forms of energy should be a high priority. However, the Trump administration has promoted only some forms of energy production (e.g. fossil fuels) while discouraging others (e.g. renewable energy). In the executive order declaring the energy emergency, “‘energy’ or ‘energy resources’ means crude oil, natural gas, lease condensates, natural gas liquids, refined petroleum products, uranium, coal, biofuels, geothermal heat, the kinetic movement of flowing water, and critical minerals” (EO 14156; White House 2025c). Notably this list does not include wind energy or solar energy, even though these are two of the least expensive and fastest growing sources of energy production in the US (USEIA 2025e), and both have well documented environmental benefits compared to fossil fuels (National Research Council 2010). Wind and solar energy have become the cheapest sources of electricity production in the US, even when only including direct production costs and ignoring environmental impacts (Lazard 2025). Over the past decade (2015–2024), net electricity generation at utility scale facilities has increased 138% for wind and 894% for solar (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025e). Over this same period, coal production fell by 42.2% (US Energy Information Administration (US EIA) 2025f). The Trump administration has gone further to handicap wind production by withdrawing all areas within the Outer Continental Shelf (OCS) from leasing for wind energy and halting approval for “onshore or offshore wind projects pending the completion of a comprehensive assessment and review of Federal wind leasing and permitting practices” (White House 2025k).

Efficient government energy policy would not play favorites with different forms of energy production, giving preferential treatment to some while handicapping others. Government energy policy should incorporate all benefits and costs of energy production and consumption (Principle 2) and should seek to internalize external benefits and costs through some type of policy, whether this is in the form of a price mechanism (e.g., tax or subsidy) or a quantity mechanism (e.g., cap-and-trade or standards) (Principle 1). Current policy under the Trump administration runs directly counter to this. For example, rather than being promoted as “clean” and “beautiful”, coal should face a hefty tax for the damages associated with CO₂ emissions and emissions of other air pollutants, including NO_x, SO₂, and mercury (see, for example National Research Council 2010; Muller et al. 2011).

3.3 Water

The two primary US statutes governing water quality in the US are the Safe Drinking Water Act and the Clean Water Act. The Safe Drinking Water Act is the primary federal law regulating harmful contaminants in public water supplies, while the Clean Water Act governs pollutants in US surface waters.⁸ The existing literature on the benefits and costs of the suite of regulations adopted under these Acts is limited, and in the case of the CWA has not unequivocally established that the total benefits exceed the costs. However, whether this is due to the lack of actual benefits or the incomplete measurement of these benefits

⁸ See Congressional Research Service (2021) for a summary of the primary provisions of the Safe Drinking Water Act and Congressional Research Service (2016) for a summary of the Clean Water Act.

remains an open question (Keiser et al. 2018). While not direct evidence of the magnitude of net benefits, there is considerable public support for protecting water quality. According to an annual Gallup poll, drinking water consistently ranks among the highest environmental concerns among American adults: 56% indicate that they worry a great deal about pollution and drinking water, and 52% express similar concerns about pollution in waterways (Gallup 2024). Despite this support, in direct violation of Principles 1 and 2, the current and previous Trump administrations have taken actions that reduce protections and investment in water quality even when the measured benefits of an action exceed the costs. Here we provide three examples to illustrate this point: lead in drinking water, regulation of per- and poly-fluoroalkyl substances (PFAS), and the definition of water of the United States (WOTUS).

The health effects of lead in drinking water were brought to national attention in 2014 by the crisis in Flint, Michigan, where residents were exposed to unsafe levels of lead in their homes (Hanna-Attisha et al. 2016; Hanna-Attisha 2019). Other cities, such as Newark, New Jersey, have experienced similar crises when it was discovered that they also had high lead levels in their drinking water (ABC News 2019). In late 2024, the EPA released a rule requiring the replacement of all remaining lead in drinking water service lines within ten years (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2024a). The rule was estimated to generate benefits that are more than ten times the costs (Levin and Schwartz 2023; US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2024a, 2024b). A key reason for these high returns on investment is that economies of scale can be achieved by replacing entire service lines in a neighborhood, rather than replacing individual household lines one at a time. In 2021, the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act was enacted (US Congress 2021) that provided, among other things, \$15 billion to speed up the replacement of drinking water service lines that contain lead, thereby achieving the cost-effectiveness that the Trump administration claims to champion. However, the Trump administration ordered a freeze on the use of these funds and EPA Administrator Zeldin indicated that the EPA is likely to revisit the rule arguing that there is a need to assure that the rule is cost-effective (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025d). Ironically, the elimination of these funds effectively removes the economies of scale that contributed to the high benefit-cost ratio of the rule. The Trump administration appears to be ignoring the significant benefits that environmental protections provide, instead focusing narrowly on costs. This story continues to evolve so the ultimate resolution remains unclear, but the Trump administration intent appears to be to reduce investments in lead removal from drinking water (Food and Water Watch 2025). Such an action would clearly be inefficient in places where removal (if done cost-effectively) would generate benefits that far exceed costs (Principle 2).

Federal and state regulations enacted over the past decade on PFAS are designed to reduce potentially significant human health and ecological risks. In 2024, under the Biden administration, the EPA announced drinking water standards on six of these compounds (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2024g). EPA estimated that the rule would reduce PFAS exposure to about 100 million people, thereby preventing thousands of deaths and illnesses, and that the annual costs for compliance with these regulations would be about \$1.5 billion/year, and the quantifiable benefits would be roughly the same size (\$1.59 billion/year). Still, they concluded that the benefits exceeded the costs when considering the substantial number of unquantified health benefits (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2024c, 2024h).

In May of 2025, under the Trump administration, the EPA announced the reconsideration of the standards for four of these compounds, effectively removing these chemicals from regulation (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025d). Additionally, the two most common of the PFAS chemicals (PFOS and PFOA) were given a two-year compliance extension. The Trump administration argued that these actions would reduce the burden on drinking water systems and the cost of water bills while continuing to protect public health (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025d). Several states have adopted protections against PFAS (California, New York, Minnesota, and Washington) for a range of consumer products. However The Guardian (2025) recently reported that the Trump administration is developing rules that would require evidence that the amount of PFAS in a single consumer product can be causally linked to health risk before it could be regulated, regardless of the cumulative effects of other exposures that a household experiences from the many products that contain these chemicals. This approach to damage assessment violates both physical science, which recognizes compound effects, and economic science which requires that all benefits and costs be accurately accounted for (Principle 2).

One of the core components of the Clean Water Act is the definition of the waters of the United States (WOTUS), which defines the bodies of water that fall under the Act's purview. This definition has been debated since the statute's initial passage. In 2015, the Obama administration issued a Clean Water Rule that provided a more inclusive definition of WOTUS (US Department of Defense 2015; US EPA 2015), supported by an assessment that demonstrated the benefits of the new definition outweighed the costs, that is, the standard economic efficiency test was passed with this widened definition. However, in 2019, the Trump administration ordered that the definition be rescinded and adopted a narrower definition, thereby reducing federal protections (US Department of Defense 2020). The Trump administration's definition excluded many wetlands, groundwater, and temporary wet areas despite the scientific consensus indicating that those water bodies are directly relevant to preserving water quality downstream, affecting drinking water quality and ecosystem health (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2015; Sullivan et al. 2019; Sullivan et al. 2020). Despite the 2020 rule being struck down by the courts, in reference to a different set of circumstances, the Supreme Court in 2023 endorsed an even narrower definition (Sackett v. EPA, 2023). It is estimated that this will result in a loss of protection for nearly 700,000 stream miles, 35 million acres of the remaining wetlands in the US, and about 30% of water bodies near drinking water sources (Gold 2024; Greenhill et al. 2024). These losses add to a long history of degradation of such water resources. More than 50% of US wetland area has been lost since the arrival of European settlers (Herrick 2019), losses that continued through the 20th Century (Dahl 2011) and indeed have substantially accelerated in recent years (Lang et al. 2024).

The extent of wetlands that will ultimately be lost from these narrowed protections will depend on the agricultural and development demand for draining, but they could be substantial with large losses in ecosystem service benefits. It is likely that such losses violate Property 2. The fact that the benefits of these wetlands very likely exceed the costs is supported by both the 2015 US EPA benefit-cost analysis and the nonmarket valuation literature, which robustly shows significant economic value of wetlands.⁹

⁹For examples of estimates see Boyer and Polasky (2004), Loomis et al. (2000), Moeltner et al. (2019), and Whitehead et al. (2009). For a more complete listing of the benefits, refer to the excellent database curated by Rosenberger (2016).

3.4 State-Level Policies

Recent actions by the Trump administration have affected environmental policy and decision-making not only at the federal level but also at the state (and potentially local) level, in ways that run counter to basic principles regarding environmental federalism (Principle 6). Two examples of this are the efforts to eliminate the ability of the State of California to set emission standards that are stricter than federal standards and the state-level “good neighbor” plan related to interstate pollution spillovers.

3.4.1 Removing the California Waiver

Section 209 of the US Clean Air Act gives the State of California the ability to petition the EPA to allow it to set motor vehicle emission standards that differ from the national standards, thereby waiving the provisions in the law that prohibit state preemption of national standards (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025e). In addition, 17 other states and the District of Columbia have been allowed to adopt some of California’s more stringent standards (CRS 2025). However, on January 20, 2025 President Trump called for a termination of “state emissions waivers that function to limit sales of gasoline-powered automobiles” (EO 14154; White House 2025b), which specifically targets the California waiver.

There is a large literature within environmental federalism that provides arguments in support of and against devolving authority to set environmental policies or regulations to lower levels of government such as states (e.g. Oates 2002; Dijkstra and Fredriksson 2010; Segerson 2020; Shobe 2020). Arguments in favor of setting policies at the lower level apply mainly to local pollutants when there is state-level heterogeneity (in costs and benefits) and local regulators have better information about local conditions than centralized (federal) regulators. Arguments in favor of more centralized policy making include the existence of interjurisdictional spillovers (which arise with regional or global pollutants) or the potential for a “race to the bottom” whereby local regulators would set standards that are “too low” to attract investment.

President Trump has justified disallowing California waivers by arguing that “It is the Federal Government, not States, that should establish vehicle emissions standards given the inherently interstate nature of air quality” (White House 2025l). However, this argument is not consistent with the prescriptions that would follow from the arguments above (summarized in Principle 6). Some emissions from motor vehicles that are major contributors to air pollution, such as NO_x and particulate matter, are local pollutants with primary impacts close to where they are emitted. Moreover, the Clean Air Act authorized the California waiver because California had “demonstrated compelling and extraordinary circumstances sufficiently different from the Nation as a whole to justify standards on automobile emissions which may, from time to time, need to be more stringent than national standards” (Congressional Research Service (CRS) 2025). Because of the unique air pollution challenges in California, basic principles of federalism (Principle 6) would support granting it the ability to set its own standards for vehicle emissions related to these local pollutants rather than forcing it to adopt less stringent standards applied in other states where the impacts of those pollutants are less severe. Furthermore, to the extent that vehicle emissions generate pollutants that cross state lines and are hence regional or global (such as

greenhouse gas emissions), the argument for federal rather than local control is based on the premise that local authorities would ignore pollution spillovers on other jurisdictions and as a result set inefficiently low standards. That argument does not apply here given that the current waiver policy allows California to set standards that are more (not less) stringent than those that would apply in other states.

3.4.2 Ending the Good Neighbor Plan

Concerns about interstate spillovers are a legitimate concern if states are allowed to set standards for regional pollutants without considering impacts on other states. For example, in 2023 the Biden administration issued rules to ensure implementation of the Clean Air Act's "Good Neighbor" requirements, which are designed to reduce interstate ozone pollution spillovers from power plants and industrial facilities in 23 states (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2023c, US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2023d). Under the Clean Air Act, states are required to develop State Implementation Plans (SIPs) that ensure that pollution originating in their state does not interfere with meeting air quality attainment goals in other states. Toward this end, the rule required that power plants in these states participate in a NO_x cap-and-trade program designed to achieve overall pollution reduction goals in a cost-effective way (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2024d). The rule has been stayed by the courts (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2024e) and in March 2025 the Trump administration called for an end to the Good Neighbor Plan (US EPA 2025a; US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025f), arguing that the policy places an undue cost burden on states and does not respect state choice (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025g). This argument is in direct contrast to the argument made by President Trump regarding the California waiver authority. Moreover, arguing states should not be required to incorporate into their SIPs consideration of how pollution in their states impacts neighboring states violates the fundamental economic principles underlying environmental federalism (Principle 6), which imply that failure of jurisdictions to consider interjurisdictional spillovers will lead to inefficient decisions.

3.5 Guidance for Regulatory Analysis

Through Executive Order "Unleashing American Energy" (EO 14154; White House 2025b), the Trump administration reversed the decision to adopt the recently updated Circular A-4, which is the Office of Management and Budget's guidance document for economic assessment and regulatory analysis across the entire federal government. By codifying a consistent set of methods and empirical regularities, such as the choice of discount rates and approaches to incorporating uncertainty, Circular A-4 ensures consistency in economic analysis across government agencies. Prior to the Biden administration, the Circular had not been updated since 2003, even though extensive research focused on both the theoretical underpinnings and empirical findings critical to accurate economic analysis had occurred. In the 2023 update to Circular A-4, many important changes were included. A few of the most significant ones were revisions to the discount rate, increased emphasis on distributional analysis, updated guidance on nonmarket valuation methods, and a focus on the fact that beneficial effects that cannot be monetized need to be carefully considered in decision-

making. These updated guidance documents apply to economic analyses across all federal agencies, including those related to climate change, air quality, water quality, and protection of public goods on public lands, and beyond environmental regulation, to all federal agencies involved in health, education, agriculture, forests, parks, and more.

Importantly, the process by which the Circular was revised was executed in accordance with the requirements of federal law, which necessitate an appropriate timeframe for public comment, independent external review, and justification of revisions (Sarinsky and Schwartz 2025). Specifically, once a revision was completed, notice of the proposed changes was issued in the Federal Register inviting comments. Over 4500 comments were submitted, which were reviewed and addressed by economists at the Information and Regulatory Affairs at the Office of Management and Budget. Additionally, a nine-member expert review panel was constituted to provide independent comments and recommendations.¹⁰ Following that review, a final draft was completed and issued in 2023. In short, the revision was thoroughly vetted under a process that followed transparent and accepted procedures.

Despite the rigorous and lengthy process for updating Circular A-4 to be consistent with state-of-the-art economic understanding and methodologies, the Trump administration summarily rejected the update and ordered a reversion to the now-outdated 2003 guidance. This was accomplished in short order, with little to no engagement with either the economic community or the public. Doing so violates deliberative processes and scientific integrity, which transcends economic principles we outlined in sect. 2, but is also important for implementation of sound policy consistent with best scientific practice.

An important example of the implications of the rejection of updated guidance relates to the discount rate used in regulatory impact analyses that is applied to all regulations across a wide range of contexts. The 2003 version of Circular A-4 (OMB 2003) recommended assessing intertemporal benefits and costs using discount rates of 3% and 7% for the social rate of time preference. Since 2003, economists have studied the appropriate discount rates to use for both short term investments (those lasting 30 years or less) and intergenerational investments (Weitzman 2001; Drupp et al. 2018; Polasky and Dampha 2021). This work has established that the rates recommended in the 2003 version of Circular A-4 are no longer appropriate. Consequently, the updated Circular established a single rate of 2% for the social rate of time preference used for short-run investments (OMB 2023, pp. 76–77) and provides a table with an appropriate range of rates for long-term discounting. Importantly, the Circular relayed plans to provide a regular update (every 3 years) to incorporate new market information and analysis (Office of Management and Budget (OMB) 2023, pp. 80–81). The return to outdated discount rate guidance, which does not reflect best available estimates of society's time preferences and the opportunity cost of capital, clearly violates Principle 3. An early example of the consequences of this violation appears in the recently released proposal to eliminate the Endangerment Finding, which reverts to the use of outdated discount rates (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025b, pp. 1–2). Using discount rates that are higher than those that represent true social values will lead to estimates of net benefits that are biased downward, potentially resulting in failure to adopt efficiency enhancing regulations.

Section 6 of “Unleashing American Energy” (EO 14154; White House 2025b) also revokes the Biden administration's 2021 memorandum entitled “Restoring Trust in Government through Scientific Integrity and Evidence-Based Policymaking,” which included the

¹⁰ As of June 24, 2025, the website containing these comments has been taken down.

statement “Scientific findings should never be distorted or influenced by political considerations” (White House 2021). That the Trump administration has revoked a memorandum on scientific integrity, along with disbanding the Interagency Working Group on the Social Cost of Greenhouse Gases, any guidance or estimates of the social cost of carbon from the Interagency Working Group, in a section entitled “Prioritizing Accuracy in Environmental Analyses” seems particularly ironic.

3.6 Deregulation Directives

Violations of foundational principles, and specifically those related to benefit-cost and cost-effectiveness analysis, occur throughout Executive Order 14192 entitled “Unleashing Prosperity Through Deregulation” (EO 14192; White House 2025m). Sect. 3, Regulatory Cap for Fiscal Year 2025, mandates that more regulations must be repealed than are adopted by a factor of 10 to 1. Further, any new regulations must cost less than the sum of the repealed regulations. The section also mandates that for Fiscal Year 2025 all agencies with new regulations must ensure that these regulations have a negative net cost (presumably meaning that costs are reduced by the eliminated regulations more than the cost of the new regulations) by the close of the fiscal year. There is no mention in the directives of the benefits of regulation or consideration of the impact on social welfare. To see the implications of this approach, consider what would happen to a business that followed such policies. The business could only introduce a new product if it eliminated 10 existing products, even if those existing products were profitable, and only if the new product cost less to produce than the existing products. While these mandates may have the effect of largely preventing the adoption of any regulatory actions at all, if they are followed, the resulting set of regulations could reduce social welfare by eliminating regulations with positive net benefits. This would directly violate Principle 2. Indeed, the only way net benefits could increase is if the one regulation adopted has large enough net benefits on its own to counterweight the 10 that are eliminated. Even in this unlikely case, assuming the 10 eliminated regulations had positive net benefits, total social welfare will be lower with this mandate than it would be if all 11 regulations were in place.

3.7 Distributional Impacts of Policies

As noted above, government policies often have goals other than efficiency, such as distributional goals. These can include improving equal opportunity and equity, particularly for historically marginalized populations. In fact, even within the economic purview of benefit-cost analysis, an important exception to decision-making based on strict adherence to a benefit-cost comparison is well accepted when benefits and costs are inequitably distributed (Arrow et al. 1995). Long-standing best practices in undertaking benefit-cost analysis, both within the federal government and in standard textbooks (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2024f; Boardman et al. 2018) therefore call for a detailed representation of the distribution of costs and benefits across income groups, geographic regions, minority status, and other subgroups of interest (Principle 5).

One of the barriers to effectively generating distributional analysis of the sort called for in these sources has been the lack of accurate data and metrics related to socioeconomic characteristics of affected populations, particularly at the relatively fine spatial scales needed

for credible analysis. The Trump administration's executive order "Ending Radical and Wasteful Government DEI Programs and Preferencing" (EO 14151; White House 2025n) shut down the Office of Environmental Justice at the EPA and removed from government websites information about government-created tools designed to provide spatially explicit information about environmental justice impacts of policies, such as EPA's environmental justice screening tool (EJScreen) and the Council on Environmental Quality's Climate and Economic Justice Screening Tool (CEJST). The elimination of these mapping tools represents an apparent rejection of the best practice for analysis of distribution (Principle 5) and is a fundamental departure from executive orders that date back to the Clinton administration and have been included by all US presidents since that time.¹¹

3.8 Science and Research

Though President Trump's stated goal is to "make America great again," Marcia McNutt, President of the National Academies of Science, Engineering, and Medicine (NASEM), has noted that "America can't be great without great science" (Galvin 2025). However, the Trump administration's actions are undermining science and research. A recent feature article in *Nature* summarized the situation: "In just the first three months of his second term, US President Donald Trump has destabilized eight decades of government support for science. His administration has fired thousands of government scientists, bringing large swathes of the country's research to a standstill and halting many clinical trials. It has threatened to slash billions in funding from US research universities and has terminated more than 1,000 grants in areas such as climate change, cancer, Alzheimer's disease and HIV prevention. This looks likely to be just the beginning" (Tollefson et al. 2025). The Trump administration has also eliminated data collection and reporting and significantly impaired the training of new and early-career scientists, thereby reducing future research capacity within the US. Many of these actions relate directly to work aimed at enhancing the protection of human health and the environment with associated impacts on welfare.

3.8.1 Eliminating Research Funding and Workforce

Since President Trump's inauguration, his administration has significantly cut or eliminated research (as well as operational) budgets for a number of environmentally related government agencies. For example, on May 2, 2025, the EPA announced plans to dissolve its Office of Research and Development (ORD), which has historically been a source of independent scientific information for the agency, and to eliminate or reassign ORD staff (National Public Radio (NPR) 2025a). Similarly, the administration's 2026 budget proposal seeks to eliminate the Ocean and Atmospheric Research (OAR) office within the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), which is a premier climate science agency (National Public Radio (NPR) 2025b; Science 2025a), and to eliminate ecosystems-related research within the US Geological Survey (Science 2025b). Other agencies, such as the US Department of Agriculture (including the US Forest Service), the US Department of Energy's Office of Science, and the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA), also face major budget cuts that will reduce the ability of these agencies to con-

¹¹ See EO12898, which contains the Clinton administration's formulation of this practice, and EO 14008 issued by the Biden administration.

duct environmental research and provide science-based input to policy decisions (Science 2025c). Related to this is the effective suspension of the federal government's work on the National Climate Assessment, a congressionally mandated assessment of climate science and impacts, and the National Nature Assessment, designed to assess the state and future of US natural resources (Nature 2025).

While sometimes difficult to quantify and involving long time lags, the return on investment of public dollars in research and development has been shown to be substantial (Jones and Williams 1998; Popp 2019). For example, an analysis of the public investments in wind energy between 1976–2017 estimated net benefits of \$31.4 billion and a benefit-cost ratio of 18 to 1 (Wiser and Millstein 2020). Similarly, estimates of the economic return on investments by the US Department of Energy's Office of Energy Efficiency and Renewable Energy for six other technologies showed substantial net economic benefits and benefit-cost ratios ranging from 2.8–1 to 197–1 (US Department of Energy 2025).

The administration is also terminating many research grants to universities and other research organizations (both nationally and internationally), primarily based on a view that the questions being studied do not align with the administration's priorities. For example, as of March 2025 under the Trump administration the EPA has eliminated over \$2 billion in grants (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025h). High among the targeted environmental topics is climate change, as well as environmental topics deemed to be related to diversity, equity, and inclusion. Studies underway have been halted through funding freezes and reviews of grant proposals have been suspended. In response to the administration's proposal to cut the budget of the National Science Foundation (NSF) in half, which is a key source of grant funding for environmental research, NSF has stopped awarding new grants until further notice. In addition to impacting scientific advancement and innovation, significant cuts to university research will have negative ripple effects beyond those institutions, given that studies from around the world have shown that universities and higher education institutions have positive effects on both GDP and employment (Schubert and Kroll 2016; Valero and Van Reenen 2019).

A recent feature article in *Science* summarized the Trump administration's first 100 days by saying:

“Since taking his oath of office on 20 January, President Donald Trump has unleashed an unprecedented rapid-fire campaign to remake—some would say demolish—vast swaths of the federal government's scientific and public health infrastructure. His administration has erased entire agencies that fund research; fired or pushed out thousands of federal workers with technical backgrounds; terminated research and training grants and contracts worth billions of dollars” (Science. 2025d).

3.8.2 Eliminating Collection and Reporting of Environmental Data and Information

Good science, as well as good decision-making, depends on having good data, and yet the Trump administration is taking steps to reduce the availability of environmentally-related data and information. A key target has been the collection and reporting of climate-related data and the removal of information about climate change from federal government websites. Immediately after President Trump was inaugurated, his administration began removing information about climate change from EPA's homepage and the USDA landing pages

related to climate change (Politico 2025; National Security Archive 2025; The Lever 2025). As noted above, the administration has also removed the web pages relating to environmental justice mapping tools that provide information on the environmental and economic vulnerability of communities. It has also taken aim at the reporting of greenhouse gas emissions under the Greenhouse Gas Reporting Program, arguing that it is too costly and does not support enforcement of an existing regulation (US Environmental Protection Agency (US EPA) 2025i). In addition, despite clear evidence of the significant economic value of weather forecasting across agricultural and industrial settings (Burlig et al. 2024; Song 2024), the administration has made staffing cuts at NOAA that affect the collection of weather-related data used for weather forecasts (PBS News 2025; WSKG Public Broadcasting 2025). NOAA has also stopped measuring the costs associated with extreme weather and climate disasters (US NOAA 2025) and tracking changes in climate change indicators such as sea ice and glacial coverage (National Snow and Ice Data Center 2025).

3.8.3 Undermining the Training of the Next Generation of Researchers

The efforts by the Trump administration to reduce or eliminate funding for research and data collection are detrimental not only to scientifically sound environmental decision-making today but also to the future of scientific discovery and innovation, with associated implications for future welfare (Science. 2025d). In discussing the importance of science and concerns about recent administration actions, Marcia McNutt of the NASEM noted:

“My biggest concern is for the pipeline of talent... I’m concerned that with the cuts in science budgets and the federal workforce, we will not see the same number of students being trained. And we are not going to see the same level of top young researchers coming to America from other countries for their education and for their jobs. Instead, the brain drain will go the other way. The best and brightest who have already gone through the system here may find that it’s too difficult to get grants to do their research, or it’s too difficult to use their education here profitably. They’ll be going to other countries, which will be only too happy to take the top American researchers” (Galvin 2025).

In fact, European countries have already begun an active effort to recruit US scientists impacted by recent cuts (WIRED 2025; New York Times 2025d).

In all these cases – whether it be cuts to research funding, data collection, or workforce training – the Trump administration is undermining the provision of a key public good, namely, research and development, where substantial public investment is likely efficient. Because so much of the research and data collection/information generated by the scientific community (both within and outside of the federal government) is a public good that would be under-provided by the market economy, the government has a critical role to play in supporting these activities in an effort to increase efficiency and welfare, both now and in the future (Principle 1). Moreover, although cutting back or eliminating support for research will generate cost-savings, this does not mean it improves efficiency once the foregone returns on those research investments are considered (Principle 2). Those returns include not only new discoveries and innovation but also, and equally importantly, better (more efficient) decisions both in the public and private sectors, as well as by individuals.

4 Discussion

During its first 100 days in office, the Trump administration initiated a host of changes covering virtually all aspects of environmental policy. As discussed in the prior section, many of these policy changes violate fundamental principles of economics regarding efficient allocation of resources. For example, Trump administration policies favor increased production of fossil fuels while ignoring their damage to public goods, such as global climate, biodiversity, air and water quality. Even if such policies reduce certain costs and create jobs for some people, they will likely cause a decline in welfare in both the short-run and long-run. Such policies also tend to concentrate benefits to small groups (e.g., resource owners) while imposing costs on the larger public. The Trump administration has also halted research programs aimed at better understanding climate change, and environmental science and economics more generally, reduced access to information, and threatened research programs critical for training the next generation of researchers. The direction of changes in the Trump administration to weaken environmental protection also runs counter to historical trends in demand for increased environmental protection both from rising incomes and increased scarcity of nature (Krutilla 1967). Trump administration policies threaten the welfare of Americans and the wider global community and may do irreversible long-term harm.

While much has already happened, many other changes will likely come: "... the story has just begun, and the end is nowhere in sight" (Science. 2025d). Further rule changes are likely, including how to administer the National Environmental Policy Act and the Endangered Species Act, fuel economy standards, possible selling of public lands or permitting more oil, gas, and mineral extraction, regulation of air pollution including rules on air toxics, and likely many other areas of environmental policy. If these future changes follow similar patterns to current environmental policy changes, there will likely be many other violations of fundamental economic principles and likely more long-lasting harms to the environment and welfare.

Now is a crucial time to push back against policy changes resulting in inefficient outcomes and the major reductions of funding for environmental research. Economists have a wealth of knowledge and expertise that can help to explain the importance of effective and efficient environmental policy and expose weaknesses in Trump administration policies. Economists can use their voice to educate the wider public on what is happening and what is at stake. As shown in numerous public opinion polls, the public broadly supports environmental protection and wants the government to do more, not less, to tackle climate change, and other environmental issues (e.g. Pew Research Center 2020; Gallup 2024). However, the public also does not rate the importance of the environment highly in comparison to other issues (Pew Research Center 2020; Gallup 2024). Therefore, mobilizing public opinion by showing what is at stake really does matter. Unpopular policies do not tend to last (e.g., super high tariffs), but there must be a groundswell of opposition for this to be effective.

As individuals or members of teams, economists can write op-eds, speak on podcasts, and create other pieces for the public, in addition to publishing in traditional academic outlets. We can also offer our expertise to environmental NGOs, both at the local and national level, and to private foundations to support research and communication. For example, after the Trump administration halted all government involvement on the National Nature Assessment, a team of scientists with support from private foundations vowed to continue

the work and produce an assessment of “how nature in the United States is doing and how it supports our health, security, culture and economy” (Levin 2025). This effort, United by Nature, has scheduled to release its report in July 2026. We can help to organize other efforts to make clear and transparent what is at stake, and how changes in environmental policy can impact the health and welfare of people. There are also many opportunities to submit formal comments on proposed changes in federal regulations. By law, the EPA must respond to all public comments. The comments and the responses of EPA are part of the public record. Groups fighting against proposed changes can file court cases and use these comments to their advantage.

By being tireless advocates for rigorous science and providing unbiased information, economists can help to overcome the current undermining of sound environmental policy and science and improve the odds that governments adopt efficient and effective environmental policies that improve health and welfare.

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